Jackson State University
School of Lifelong Learning

Course Number and Title: CLL 484-61: Artificial Intelligence Essentials for the Workforce

Semester and Year: Fall 2026

Credit Hours: Three (3) semester hours

Class Time & Location: Tuesday/Thursdays 12:00 PM-1:20 PM; COE 304

Instructor Information

Instructor Name:	**Dr. Shyamal S. Pandya**
Office Location:	3-2, Universities Center
Office Hours:	By Appointment
Phone:	601-979-8890
Email:	shyamal.s.pandya@jsums.edu or Canvas Inbox (Responses Will Be Provided Within 48 Hours During Weekdays)

Course Description

This course explores the applications of artificial intelligence (AI) in the modern workforce and across diverse industries. Through hands-on engagement with AI tools and emerging technologies, students will develop practical skills in AI literacy, human-AI collaboration, prompt design, critical thinking, workflow optimization, ethical decision-making, and responsible AI use. Students will examine how AI is transforming communication, productivity, innovation, and organizational performance while evaluating opportunities and challenges associated with AI adoption. As part of the course, students will have access to the School of Lifelong Learning's Artificial Intelligence (AI) Lab, where they will have the opportunity to be exposed to and explore emerging AI technologies, experiment with AI tools, and apply classroom concepts in a collaborative, hands-on learning environment. The course culminates in an AI Innovation Project and professional presentation in which students design, evaluate, or propose an AI-enabled solution to address a real-world organizational, industry, business, or community problem.

Course Prerequisites

None.

Course Objectives

- Explain the fundamental concepts, capabilities, and limitations of artificial intelligence in workplace and organizational settings.
- Evaluate the opportunities and challenges associated with AI adoption across industries and professions.
- Apply AI tools and technologies to enhance communication, productivity, problem-solving, and decision-making.
- Develop effective prompts and strategies for interacting with generative AI systems.
- Analyze AI-generated outputs for accuracy, quality, bias, and reliability.
- Apply critical thinking skills to assess AI-enabled solutions and workplace applications.

- Demonstrate ethical and responsible AI use, including considerations related to privacy, security, transparency, and fairness.
- Identify opportunities for integrating AI into organizational processes, products, services, and workflows.
- Research and evaluate emerging AI tools, trends, and innovations relevant to workforce success.
- Design innovative AI-enabled solutions to address real-world organizational, business, industry, or community challenges.
- Communicate AI-related ideas, recommendations, and solutions clearly and professionally through written and oral presentations.
- Explore and experiment with emerging AI technologies to develop practical, workforce-ready AI competencies through hands-on learning experiences in the SLL AI Lab.

JSU V.I.B.E.

Textbooks and/or course materials for this course are included in the Jackson State University V.I.B.E. program. For students who are participating in the V.I.B.E. program, digital textbooks and/or course materials will be automatically loaded into Canvas by the first day of class. If digital versions are not available, hard copies can be picked up at the JSU Campus Store. Any questions related to the V.I.B.E. program or textbooks can be directed to the JSU Campus Store (jsu@bkstr.com or 601-979-5801). For more information about JSU V.I.B.E, please visit https://www.jsums.edu/auxiliary/jsuvibe/.

Required Textbook

Taulli, T. (2019). *Artificial Intelligence Basics: A Non-Technical Introduction*. Apress. ISBN-13: 978-1484250273

Recommended Textbooks

American Psychological Association (2019). *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.). Washington, DC: American Psychological Association. ISBN-13: 978-1433805615

Knappertsbusch, I., & Gondlach, K. (2023). *Work and AI 2030: Challenges and Strategies for Tomorrow's Work*. Springer Nature. ISBN-13: 978-3658402327

Technology Requirement

- JSU provides the following software to all students and faculty for free download: Microsoft Office 365 (Word, Excel, and PowerPoint), SAS, and Mathematica (https://www.jsums.edu/informationtechnology/).
- View technical requirements for (online, hybrid, or supplemental) courses that use the Canvas Instructure platform.

Technical Support

For 24/7 assistance, contact the Canvas Helpdesk at 1-844-358-8765 or click the Help icon inside Canvas. For assistance Monday-Friday from 8:00 to 5:00 contact the JSU Helpdesk at canvas@jsums.edu or 601-979-0245.

Course Structure

To accomplish the learning outcomes of this course, students will engage in a variety of hands-on learning experiences designed to develop practical artificial intelligence (AI) knowledge and workforce-ready skills. The course is delivered in a face-to-face format and emphasizes active learning, collaboration, real-world applications, critical thinking, ethical decision-making, and innovative problem-solving.

Instructional activities may include lectures, demonstrations of AI tools and emerging technologies, class discussions, case studies, workshops, guest speakers, guided activities, industry-focused exercises, research activities, and individual and group projects. Students will have opportunities to explore and evaluate AI applications across a variety of industries and professional contexts while developing practical skills that can be applied in the workplace.

Throughout the semester, students will progressively develop an AI Innovation Project focused on addressing a real-world organizational, business, industry, entrepreneurial, or community challenge through the application of AI. Students will have the flexibility to select a project pathway aligned with their professional interests and career goals, culminating in a professional presentation of their AI-enabled solution.

An outline of weekly topics, learning activities, and associated course materials is provided in the Course Schedule. Students are responsible for completing all assigned readings, participating actively in class discussions and activities, engaging with AI tools and technologies, and contributing meaningfully to the learning environment. Regular attendance and active participation are essential for success in this rapidly evolving and highly applied field.

Grading Criteria

Performance in this course will be evaluated according to the following criteria:

Assignments	Points	%
Attendance & Participation	20	20
Applied AI Activity 1: AI Research & Intelligence Brief	10	10
Applied AI Activity 2: AI Content Creation Challenge	10	10
Applied AI Activity 3: AI Workflow & Productivity Optimization	10	10
Applied AI Activity 4: AI Image Replication Challenge	10	10
AI Innovation Project & Presentation	40	40
Total Points	100	100

Your final grade in the course is based on the **total points** you earn throughout the semester.

Points	Final %	Grade
90 and above	90-100%	A
80 – 89	80-89%	B
70 – 79	70-79%	C
60 - 69	60-69%	D
Less than 60	<60%	F

Expectations for Written Assignments

Clear, well-organized writing is essential to success in this course. Students are expected to submit high-quality written work that demonstrates careful thinking, logical organization, and adherence to scholarly standards.

The instructor is available to provide clarification and guidance throughout the semester. Drafts may be reviewed **with at least one week's advance notice** prior to the assignment due date. Work submitted on the due date is considered final; **revisions or rewrites will not be accepted after submission for grading purposes.**

All written assignments will be evaluated based on the following criteria:

- **Clarity** – Ideas are clearly and coherently expressed.
- **Relevance** – Content directly addresses the purpose of the assignment.
- **Defensibility** – Claims are supported with appropriate reasoning and evidence.
- **Convention** – Writing follows academic and formatting standards.

All assignments must be **word-processed and formatted in APA 7th edition style**, including double spacing, 12-point Times New Roman font, 1-inch margins, and page numbers. An APA7 formatted cover page must be included on all written assignments. Assignments that do not meet the requirements outlined in this syllabus **will not be graded.**

Attendance & Participation (20%)

Regular attendance and active participation are essential to success in this course. Students are expected to attend class, actively engage in discussions and hands-on activities, participate in demonstrations and collaborative learning experiences, and contribute meaningfully to the classroom environment. Because this course emphasizes experiential learning and practical application of AI tools, many in-class activities cannot be replicated outside of class.

Participation also includes arriving prepared, engaging professionally with classmates and guest speakers, and actively experimenting with AI technologies during class. Attendance and participation will be evaluated throughout the semester, and excessive absences or lack of meaningful participation may result in a reduction of the final course grade.

Applied AI Activity 1: AI Research & Intelligence Brief (10%)

Students will use AI-powered research and information retrieval tools (e.g., ChatGPT,

Perplexity, Gemini, Claude, or Microsoft Copilot) to investigate an emerging workforce, business, technology, or industry trend. Students will evaluate the accuracy, credibility, and reliability of AI-generated information, verify key findings using credible sources, and prepare a professional intelligence brief that summarizes key insights, opportunities, challenges, and recommendations.

Applied AI Activity 2: AI Content Creation Challenge (10%)

Students will use generative AI tools to design professional-quality content for a real or hypothetical organization. Students may choose to create marketing materials, training resources, presentations, business communications, social media campaigns, images, videos, websites, or other workplace deliverables that address a specific organizational goal or challenge. Students will apply prompt engineering techniques to generate, refine, and improve their content while evaluating the quality, creativity, accuracy, and effectiveness of the final product.

Applied AI Activity 3: AI Workflow & Productivity Optimization (10%)

Students will identify a workplace process, professional task, or organizational workflow that could be improved through the use of artificial intelligence. Students will analyze the existing process, identify inefficiencies or challenges, and develop an AI-enhanced solution designed to improve productivity, efficiency, decision-making, quality, or customer experience. Students will present their proposed workflow and explain the expected benefits, implementation considerations, and potential limitations of the AI solution.

Applied AI Activity 4: AI Image Replication Challenge (10%)

Students will be provided with an instructor-selected AI-generated reference image and challenged to recreate it as accurately as possible using AI image-generation tools. Through multiple rounds of prompt refinement and experimentation, students will develop stronger prompt engineering, writing, and critical thinking skills by learning how clarity, specificity, and structure influence AI-generated outputs. Students will submit their final image, prompt iterations, and a brief reflection describing their prompting strategy and lessons learned.

AI Innovation Project & Professional Presentation (40%)

The AI Innovation Project is the culminating assignment for this course and provides students with an opportunity to apply artificial intelligence to a real-world challenge, opportunity, or organizational need. Students will select one of the project pathways below to demonstrate their ability to leverage AI creatively, strategically, and responsibly to develop innovative, practical, and impactful solutions. Projects should integrate the concepts, tools, and techniques learned throughout the course and culminate in a professional presentation showcasing the proposed solution, its implementation, and its potential impact. Students may choose from one of the project pathways described below.

Project Pathways

Students must select one of the following project pathways:

1. Custom AI Assistant Development

Design and develop a custom AI assistant, chatbot, GPT, or other AI-powered tool that addresses a specific professional, organizational, educational, or community need. Students should demonstrate how the solution functions, explain the prompting strategy used to develop it, and discuss its intended purpose, value, limitations, and potential impact.

2. Business AI Integration Plan

Select a business, nonprofit organization, government agency, educational institution, or community organization and develop a strategic plan for integrating AI into one or more organizational functions. Students should identify an existing challenge or opportunity, evaluate appropriate AI tools, and recommend an implementation strategy that improves efficiency, productivity, decision-making, customer service, training, marketing, operations, or other organizational processes.

3. AI for Wicked Problem Solving

Identify a complex real-world problem affecting society, organizations, industries, communities, or the workforce, and develop an AI-enabled solution to address the challenge. Students should explain the significance of the problem, describe how AI can contribute to a solution, and evaluate the feasibility, potential benefits, limitations, and ethical implications of the proposed approach.

4. Student-Proposed Project

Students may propose an alternative AI-related project that aligns with the learning objectives of the course and demonstrates equivalent rigor, creativity, innovation, and practical application. The proposal must clearly define the project objectives, expected outcomes, and the role of AI in the proposed solution. All proposed projects must receive instructor approval before work begins.

Guidelines for Late Work

All assignments are due on the day and time specified. Assignments submitted after the due date and time will be considered **LATE**. Late assignments will not be eligible for a perfect score. The maximum grade for late work will begin at a "B" or lower, depending on how late the submission is. Assignments will **NOT** be accepted after the **Acceptance Deadline**, which is 5:00 PM, two days after the original due date. Assignments will be submitted via Canvas.

Email Policy

The preferred method for communication outside communicating before, during, or after class in this course is email. I check my email several times per day. When using e-mail, it is critical that you follow the following protocol:

- You must use your official JSU email account. I will not, under any circumstances, send emails to Hotmail, Yahoo mail, Gmail, or other 3rd party clients. There are legal and privacy issues that need to be followed.
- Your course number goes first in the subject line.
- All emails must have a proper salutation.

- All emails MUST have your name at the end of your message.
- All emails must be typographically and grammatically correct. These are professional and formal written documents, and the same care and diligence should be used for their creation. Emails with typos and hideous grammatical errors will be deleted.
- Finally, remember that conveying any kind of tone in an email is nearly impossible, so be careful that you do not convey the wrong message. It is not in your best interest to send your instructors email that appears to be angry, demanding, or condescending, especially if you are asking for some sort of dispensation or assistance.

Library Services

All students on campus and at a distance have access to the resources available at the JSU Libraries. Please visit the JSU Libraries or the JSU Library Services for Distance Learners websites for more information.

Jackson State University Policies

JSU Honor Code: I will be honest in all my academic course work and will not indulge in or tolerate the academic dishonesty of my counterparts or peers. I will not partake in any type of misconduct, misrepresentation, or immoral behavior that will harm, damage or endanger any person, property or myself or reflect negatively against me or hinder my academic continuance. I will strive to achieve excellence and to complete degree requirements without hesitation. I am a valuable part of the Jackson State University family and proud of it.

Academic Dishonesty

Cheating Includes:

- Submitting material not yours as part of your course performance, such as copying from another student's exam, allowing a student to copy from your exam.
- Using information or devices not allowed by the faculty, such as formulas or data from a home computer program or using unauthorized materials for a take-home exam.
- Obtaining and using unauthorized material, such as a copy of an examination before it is given.
- Fabricating information, such as the data for a lab report.
- Violating procedures prescribed to protect the integrity of an assignment, test, or other evaluation.
- Collaborating with others on assignments without the faculty's consent.
- Cooperating with or helping another student to cheat; and
- Participating in or performing other forms of dishonest behavior, such as having another person take an examination in your place or altering exam answers without permission.

Plagiarism Includes:

- Directly quoting the words of others without using quotation marks or indented format to identify them.
- Using sources of information (published or unpublished) without identifying them.
- Paraphrasing materials or ideas of others without identifying the sources.
- Submitting themes, essays, term papers, tests, and other similar requirements that are not the work of the student; and
- Failing to appropriately acknowledge direct quotations and the idea of another when incorporated in papers.

Students are expected to follow all standards of academic integrity in their written work. If there is any uncertainty regarding the proper use of sources or materials, students should consult the instructor for clarification.

In general, any time a source is used, whether directly or indirectly, it must be properly cited. This includes instances where ideas are paraphrased in the student's own words. Simply substituting synonyms while retaining the original sentence structure is not acceptable and constitutes improper paraphrasing.

Effective paraphrasing requires both a change in wording and a restructuring of the original sentence. Direct quotations must be clearly indicated and properly cited. Acceptable documentation methods (e.g., in-text citation) will follow the format specified by the instructor.

Compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act

If you have a disability for which you are or may be requesting an accommodation, you are encouraged to contact both your instructor and ADA Coordinator (as early as possible in the term) located in the Jacob L. Reddix Building (old student union), rooms 101 and 102. The office hours are: 8:00 a. m. to 5:00 p.m., Monday through Friday. The telephone number is (601) 979-3704 or (601) 979-6919 (TTY) and the facsimile number is (601) 979-6918. The mailing address is: Office of Support Services for Students and Employees with Disabilities, PO Box 17156, Jackson State University, Jackson, MS 39217.

See the Office of Disability Services website for more information.
For more information on the Jackson State student policies, see the Student Handbook.

Method of Course Evaluation

All students are asked to complete the Jackson State University Student Instructional Rating System (SIRS) – P.A.W.S.

JSU Artificial Intelligence Policy

Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) can be a useful tool that can accelerate learning. This

policy recognizes the pace at which AI is evolving, and as such, this policy may adjust based on this evolution at the course instructor's discretion. Please be advised that individual faculty, departments, and/or colleges may have additional criteria in their syllabus for using AI which does not conflict with this policy. The goal of integrating AI in education is to supplement student learning, not to replace human creativity, ingenuity, or critical thinking. Thus, AI use is permissible when used for specific tasks as noted and approved by the course instructor. With instructor approval, students may use AI platforms in the following ways:

- to help brainstorm assignments, presentations, design ideation, etc.;
- to create a plan, outline and generate examples for assignments;
- to summarize or synthesize sources to enhance understanding;
- to learn prompt engineering; crafting precise inputs (prompts) to guide AI models
- to assist in finding, analyzing, and researching sources;
- to help understand different perspectives or viewpoints; and
- to enhance, improve, edit or revise their own original work (artistic, musical, written, etc.).

These options are with the understanding that (generative) AI is a simulation platform that can quickly generate a variety of outputs that may be helpful but may also be flawed. However, no final assignment, presentation, paper, or other graded work can be fully created by AI, unless using AI to that end is the assignment. At the instructor's discretion, any assignments or coursework for a grade that is fully created by AI will receive a zero for that specific assignment. The unauthorized use of AI is a form of academic dishonesty. If AI is utilized for any graded work, the submitted work must cite such usage properly in accordance with current citation formats (MLA, APA, Chicago, etc.). The use of AI without proper citation is also a form of academic dishonesty. Guidance and examples of AI citations from the main three style manuals are below.

American Psychological Association: https://apastyle.apa.org/blog/how-to-cite-chatgpt

Modern Language Association: https://style.mla.org/citing-generative-ai/

Chicago Manual of Style:
https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/qanda/data/faq/topics/Documentation/faq0422.html

Members of the JSU community are prohibited from inputting any personal, sensitive, or otherwise confidential information that is protected under the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act, the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act, and the Americans with Disabilities Act into any AI program.

Dr. Pandya's Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy

There has never been a more interesting—or dangerous—time to be a student. Artificial intelligence tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Claude, and Grammarly can produce polished outputs in seconds. That is precisely why this course is not interested in polished output.

This course is interested in **how you think**.

Much like in real-world consulting, leadership, and professional practice, your value is not in producing answers—it is in **framing problems, exercising judgment, and defending decisions under ambiguity**. AI can assist with that process. It cannot replace it.

In fact, some assignments in this course are intentionally designed to be **"AI-resistant"**—meaning they require human judgment, real-time reasoning, and the ability to explain your thinking in ways that cannot be outsourced.

With that in mind, use the following as your operating model.

If AI is helping you think, you are doing it right.
If AI is thinking for you, you are not doing the work.

Think about your use of AI through a continuous traffic light.

A **green light** means go. You should be using AI when it sharpens your thinking—when it helps you brainstorm, challenge assumptions, explore alternative perspectives, clarify difficult concepts, or organize your ideas more effectively. Professionals use tools to think better, and this is no different. If AI is making your reasoning more precise, more critical, and more structured, you are operating at the level expected in this course.

A **yellow light** means proceed carefully. This is where AI begins to shape your work in ways that can quietly reduce your intellectual ownership. Rewriting sections, expanding your ideas, or generating examples that resemble assignment responses fall into this space. At this level, you must remain fully in control. You should be able to explain every claim, defend every decision, and clearly connect your work to course concepts without relying on AI. If your work sounds polished but lacks depth, this is where the issue usually originates.

A **red light** means stop. You may not submit AI-generated work as your own, copy or lightly modify AI responses, or use AI to complete assignments you do not understand. You may not outsource analysis, interpretation, or argumentation. You may not rely on AI in ways that bypass the purpose of the assignment. If AI is doing the intellectual work, then the assignment has not been completed—regardless of how good the output looks.

Transparency is expected, not optional. If you use AI in any meaningful way, you must disclose it.

A simple statement is sufficient:
"I used AI to support brainstorming, idea development, or clarity. All final work reflects my own reasoning."

Failure to disclose AI use is not a technicality—it is a violation of trust and academic integrity.

You are accountable for your thinking. At any point, you may be asked to explain your reasoning, walk through how you arrived at your conclusions, or defend your work in real time. Inability to do so is evidence that the work is not your own, regardless of how it was produced.

Before submitting any work, ask yourself three questions: Could I explain this without AI? Do I actually understand what I wrote? Would this hold up in a live conversation? If the answer is no, revise.

This course is designed to help you work effectively alongside Artificial Intelligence (AI) while maintaining independent critical thinking and academic integrity. Success in this course depends not on the extent of AI use, but on the ability to use it with discipline, awareness, and control. In the end, AI is just a tool. Your thinking is the product.

In accordance with JSU policy and the School of Lifelong Learning guidelines, any use of generative AI must be properly cited within the assignment. The AI-generated content score reported by Turnitin must remain below 20%.

Assignments with an AI-generated content score of 20% or higher will receive a zero. Students will have one week to revise and resubmit the assignment. A one-letter-grade deduction will be applied before the revised assignment is graded.

Course Schedule Fall 2026: CLL 484-61

Week	Dates	Topic & Readings	Assignments/ Deliverables
1 Online	8/11/26	Introduction to Course	
	8/13/26	Artificial Intelligence and the Modern Workforce; Taulli Ch. 1 (pp. 1-19)	Attendance Verification Due 8/14/26 by 11:59 PM
2 Face-to-Face	8/18/26	Prompt Engineering and Effective AI Communication; Taulli Ch. 2 (pp. 19-39)	
	8/20/26		
3 Online	8/25/26	AI Research and Information Retrieval; Taulli Ch. 3 (pp. 39-69)	Applied AI Activity 1: AI Research & Intelligence Brief Due 8/28/26 by 11:59 PM
	8/27/26		
4 Face-to-Face	9/1/26	AI Practice Session	
	9/3/26		
5 Online	9/8/26	AI Content Design and Creativity; Taulli Ch. 4 (pp. 69-91)	Applied AI Activity 2: AI Content Creation Challenge Due 9/11/26 by 11:59 PM
	9/10/26		
6 Face-to-Face	9/15/26	AI Workflow Optimization and Process Improvement; Taulli Ch. 5 (pp. 91-103)	
	9/17/26		
7 Online	9/22/26	AI Integration Across Organizations and Industries	Applied AI Activity 3: AI Workflow & Productivity Optimization Due 9/25/26 by 11:59 PM
	9/24/26		
8 Face-to-Face	9/29/26	AI Image Generation and Prompt Engineering; Taulli Ch. 6 (pp. 103-125)	
	10/1/26		
9 Online	10/6/26	Advanced Prompt Engineering and Prompt Optimization	Applied AI Activity 4: AI Prompt Engineering Challenge Due 10/9/26 by 11:59 PM
	10/8/26		
10 Face-to-Face	10/13/26	AI Assistants, Agents, and Custom GPTs; Taulli Ch. 7 (pp. 125-143)	AI Innovation Project Pathway Selection Due in 10/15/26 Class
	10/15/26		
11 Online	10/20/26	AI Strategy, Ethics, and Responsible Implementation; Taulli Ch. 8 (pp. 143-161)	
	10/22/26		
12 Face-to-Face	10/27/26	AI Innovation Project Development Workshop; Taulli Ch. 9 (pp. 161-177)	
	10/29/26		
13 Online	11/3/26	AI Innovation Project Studio	
	11/5/26		
14 Face-to-Face	11/10/26	Presentation Preparation and Project Refinement	
	11/12/26	AI Innovation Project Presentations	
15 Face-to-Face	11/17/26	AI Innovation Project Presentations	Last Day of Classes
	11/19/26		Final AI Innovation Project Due 11/20/26 by 11:59 PM
16 Online	11/24/26		
	11/26/26		

Bibliography/References

American Psychological Association (2019). *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.).

Chang, Y., & Ke, J. (2023). Socially Responsible Artificial Intelligence Empowered People Analytics: A Novel framework towards Sustainability. *Human Resource Development Review*, *23*(1), 88–120. https://doi.org/10.1177/15344843231200930

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Pandya, S. S., Henderson, T., Shirazi, H. P., & Beyerlein, M. M. (2025). ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN ORGANIZATION DEVELOPMENT: A SCOPING REVIEW. *Performance Improvement Quarterly*, *37* (4), 161–174. https://doi.org/10.56811/piq-24-004

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